

CHAPTER FOUR

**My College Years
BYU And Columbia**

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PART ONE

It didn't take long to start running into my old high school friends most of whom were also back from the war. One of the girls that I knew, named Rayola Smith, daughter of David Smith, our Stake President, was around so I dated her for awhile. I had been corresponding with U.C.L.A. about matriculating there since it had a good political science department, but I ran across Kay Young, who graduated the same year I did from Idaho Falls High, and who was attending BYU. He convinced me that there were a lot of girls there just waiting for servicemen to return and that I would enjoy the atmosphere at the Y much better. So I wrote to BYU and shortly received word that I had been accepted to start the winter quarter, about the 5th of January, of 1946. Sometime before I left Idaho Falls I was asked to speak at a Stake Conference. Elder Harold B. Lee, a member of the Quorum of the Twelve, was the visiting representative from Salt Lake City. He later became President of the Church.

Took a bus to Salt Lake City, then the old Orem line from there to Provo. I had been in correspondence with a fellow that I worked with at the PBO, Floyd E. Graham, who had been my ward-teaching companion when I went to the 12th Ward in Salt Lake City and who was a student at the Y. He lived in a house on No. University so I took a room there and stayed in those quarters until I got married. I really don't remember too much about my first year. Because of my military credits and the college training I had received at naval training schools I received quite a few hours of constructive credit. I was anxious to complete my undergraduate work as quickly as possible so I took a lot of hours in the winter, spring and summer quarters and was about the equivalent of a Junior by the fall of 1946. I studied political science and Russian as well as filling the normal group requirements. Dr. Hugh Nibley was my Russian language instructor.

During my first year at the BYU, I dated quite a few girls but not anyone steadily. I had met Marion Jones in connection with the International Relations clubs. She was a Provo resident and a big wheel on the campus and we attended some of the same classes. I dated her a few times in the Fall of 1946 after I had been elected Vice-President of the Val Hyric social unit. She went to Sun Valley to work over the Christmas holidays in December of 1946 and I rode on the same train with her since I was going home for Christmas. We passed through a tunnel and I stole my first kiss from her. When winter quarter began in January 1947, we started to date pretty regularly. By the early spring I decided she was the girl for me and I pinned her with my Val Hyric pin, followed with an engagement ring about a month before the school year ended. Instead of continuing in

summer school, I went home to Idaho Falls to work (as a carpenter's helper on a construction project), while Marion and her family prepared for our wedding set for September 11, 1947. I actually saw Marion only twice during the summer. She came to Idaho Falls to meet my mother and talk to my Bishop, Vernon S. Johnson, and for the first time saw the humble abode in which I had spent my years since I had been in junior high. She also got her first airplane ride when I sent her home by plane from Idaho Falls. We saw each other again during the 24th of July celebration in Salt Lake City. Howard and Ila Anderson were there and we stayed with some friends of theirs, during which time Ila took advantage of the situation to tell Marion all the dirt about me, but it didn't seem to change her mind.

My mother came down from Idaho Falls for the wedding but the strain of a lot of illness overcame her and she had a breakdown just before our reception. Martin, who was supposed to have been my best man, spent the time of the reception in the hospital. A friend, Mel Mabey, filled in for him. Our reception was a splendid affair and was held in the Joseph Smith building lounge. Many of the faculty of BYU attended since Marion and her family were so well-known and since Marion had graduated in May 1947, she was serving as the secretary for the then President of the university, Howard S. McDonald. We went to Carmel-By-The-Sea and San Francisco for our honeymoon, flying there in a C-47. After we returned I started my senior year. We lived in the old Wymount Village which didn't offer great accommodations but we were happy and Marion was close where she could telephone her mother for counsel and advice (mostly on cooking).

Unfortunately the situation with my mother's health never improved. She went to stay with Ila for a few months but needed constant medical care having suffered virtually a complete nervous collapse. The techniques for dealing with these matters was not very well developed and eventually we had no choice but to commit her to a hospital in Blackfoot, Idaho, which presumably could treat her adequately. Apparently, this never happened or she was too far gone because shortly after the ushering in of 1948, we were informed that Mother had died while in Blackfoot on January 3, 1948. Marion and I immediately contacted people in Idaho Falls who had known Mother for many years and who were able to make funeral arrangements for us, since it was difficult to do so from down in Provo. We went to Idaho Falls on a bus and the funeral had many good speakers such as our former Stake President David Smith who had known our family for many years. After her internment at Rose Hill cemetery along side my grandfather, Solomon Webster Harris, Ila Rose and I spent a day going through Mother's personal effects and did what we could to dispose of them. I know that there were a lot of things that we would have liked to save but our circumstances did not permit their retention. Our

bishop in Idaho Falls was a real estate agent and arranged to dispose of the house for about \$3200 and that sum was divided amongst the four children.

PART TWO

I was a member of several clubs during my college years mostly those involved in political affairs, international relations and service activities such as the International Relations Club, the BYser club, Russian club, and the Blue Key national service club. During my junior year our group attended a conference in Denver of all International Relations clubs in the western intermountain area. As the result of the political maneuvering that a close friend (Frank William Gay, who later became a well-known public figure for serving as the right hand man of Howard Hughes, the eccentric billionaire of that period) and I did, I obtained the nomination to be president of all the Intermountain International Relations Clubs (Colorado, Utah, Wyoming and New Mexico universities) and my election was practically unanimous. We then discovered that the college which had the presidency had the responsibility for holding the conference the next year.

Our advisor (Prof. Carr) was somewhat of a Caspar Milquetoast and wouldn't call long distance to obtain permission for BYU to hold the conference. Consequently, we adopted the tactic of my stepping down to be the Executive Vice-President and elected someone from the University of Utah as the president. However, the responsibilities of the president the next year were largely representational and ceremonial. I as the Executive Vice-President got to run the show. We staged a mock United Nations and my responsibilities ranged from setting up all the committees, appointing chairmen, and arranging for national and internationally known speakers, competent and knowledgeable in the field of international affairs. The conference lasted approximately three days, and received extensive newspaper coverage.

During my senior year, in addition to the activities in the International Relations Clubs, I was asked to be a student teacher in first year Russian, having been recommended by Dr. Hugh Nibley. My class consisted of approximately thirty students. Marion and I engaged in a lot of school activities together, being amongst other things responsible for one of the school dances at Christmas time. I graduated from Brigham Young University in June of 1948 with a Bachelor of Arts degree in the upper 5% of the class with a grade point average of 3.86 on a scale of 4.00. Some of the friends who were in my graduating class were Clark Knowlton, Tom Taylor, Leo Wadsworth, and Grant Larsen. My sister Ila Rose came up from California to attend my graduation. Desiring to pursue a career in foreign affairs,

I applied for several scholarships, including a Rhodes Scholarship. I was offered a three year scholarship at Vanderbilt University in Nashville, Tenn, and a two-year partial scholarship at Columbia University in New York City. The latter had just initiated a Russian Institute connected with it's fledgeling School of International Affairs. It was too good of an opportunity to pass up, so I opted to accept the offer from Columbia. Also, world events had started shaping up pretty well as I had concluded several years earlier when I decided to go into international affairs. In 1948 the Soviet Union started its imperialistic expansion, throughout 1947 and 1948 communists had seized governments in Bulgaria, Hungary, Czechoslovakia and Poland. The infamous Berlin "blockade" was initiated by land and the only way supplies could be brought into that beleaguered city was by an air lift, which the U.S. and its allies ran for many months. In 1948 Israel was set up as a separate country and the Arab nations started hostilities immediately.

PART THREE

After graduation in June, 1948, Marion and I flew to New York City. We stayed initially in an apartment with someone on Riverside Drive, later moving to a temporary place on Central Park West. I obtained a job with Lord and Taylor's department store in the women's swimwear department but soon an opportunity came to work for the RCA Service Co. which advertised for ex-radio technicians of the Navy to help in the fledgling television field. While applying I ran across several of my shipmates from the Wasp. Marion got a job immediately as a secretary with R.H.Macy Associates. We did not own a car so we relied on subway transportation which in New York was quite adequate for our needs. We found out that Marion was pregnant so she found it difficult to deal with the heat and smells of downtown New York City. My friend, Harold Price, from Idaho Falls visited us about this time either on his way to or from his mission in Switzerland.

My work consisted primarily of installing antennae for television sets in NYC apartments. TV was quite new in terms of mass production and still an oddity. I recall people grouped together peering through windows of a store displaying TV and watching a boxing match. Installing antennae was quite complicated in view of the heights of the buildings. We often had a situation where the owner's apartment might be on the 12th floor and the building was 25 or 30 stories high so we had to install a rooftop antenna, drop a lead down to the 12th story, run it through the window and then go from apartment to apartment all the way up to fasten the lead to the building. All in all it was quite interesting work (I worked as a member of a two man team) and I got to see parts of Manhattan that I never expected to see, from Gracie Mansion, the official residence

of the Mayor of New York to the very wealthy apartments of Park Avenue to ones where a thousand dollar TV was being put in a Harlem dump.

Since the apartment where we stayed was only rented for the summer, we eventually had to find other quarters. We ultimately moved, just before the beginning of the school year, to a student housing area known as Shanks Village in Orangeburg, N. Y, about 20 miles north of NYC on the west side of the Hudson River. Transportation to and from New York was obtained by a carpool method. Certain spots were designated for pickup both in Shanks and near Columbia University. When a car came by, one simply hopped in and paid 25 cents each way to cover George Washington bridge tolls and gasoline expenses. This sufficed pretty well for us but after a year we bought a 1939 Buick for transportation and thus became part of the car pool drivers as well.

While going to the Manhattan Ward we met a lot people who were helpful to us during our time in New York. I was also a member of the Elder's Quorum presidency for a while until after our move to Shanks made it very difficult to perform my responsibilities adequately. We became good friends with Boyd and Margaret Thomas, whom we had known at the Y but not very well. Boyd, after his graduation from the Columbia University Law School, went to Idaho Falls on my recommendation and contacted Bp. Vernon S. Johnson. Boyd later became a judge in that area. We also had occasion to visit frequently with Don and Kay Bowen, whom we knew at the Y since he was a member of the same social unit, the Val Hyrics. Don was getting a PhD at New York University. We were also good friends of Stan and Elaine Gwilliam, also former BYU students, and Maxwell and Ruth Lund, all of whom were fellow residents at Shanks Village and members of the Manhattan Ward.

Working at the Columbia University Bookstore (actually the part that sold supplies, tickets, etc.) provided us with an occasional opportunity to go to the Manhattan theatrical events. If people ordered tickets that weren't picked up by a certain time, the employees could use them so frequently I would give Marion a call, she would catch a carpool ride into Manhattan and we would take in a play or an opera. Otherwise, we never could have afforded to go since tickets for such events are always quite high-price, particularly for students. Because of the distance at which we lived, Marion was unable to keep her job at Macy Associates so she helped supplement our income by typing Masters' theses and doctoral dissertations (without the benefit of the modern miracle of the word processor.)

We had a lot of great social activity with our friends in Shanks as well as a good relationship with the members in the Manhattan Ward, most of whom were graduate students attending one or another of the New York area universities. On one occasion our ward was visited by Leo Durocher. He was a former manager of the Brooklyn Dodgers, and his wife, an LDS actress named Laraine Day. We also had several high-level executives of well-known businesses who were members. 1948 was an election year and, of course, was the first time since 1932 that someone was running on the Democratic ticket besides Franklin D. Roosevelt and that was the vice-president who had become the president upon FDR's death, Harry S. Truman. We wanted to vote in this election so we had to register and to do so were required to take a literacy test. Quite amusing since we were graduate students at a university. Opposing Truman was the Governor of New York, Thomas E. Dewey, and the polls favored him highly. Of course, as history recalls, Dewey was soundly defeated by Truman and a lot of forecasters had egg all over their faces.

Our first child, Ronald Sidney Harris, was born on February 16, 1949. This was an adventure in itself. While I was at school, Marion went in to New York City to do some shopping and make a routine visit with her obstetrician. While at his office, her water broke so she was sent over to Columbia Presbyterian Hospital to deliver the baby. In the meantime, I was on my way on a usual carpool ride back to Shanks Village where I found a note pinned to the door by a neighbor to whom she had managed to get the word. So back I went to New York and went to the hospital to await the birth of our first child. I was eventually shown the child, after having had him shown to someone else first.

Marion's mother, Rhoda Jones, came out to stay with us for awhile to help Marion with the newborn. She was rather taken back at where we lived, never having seen converted Army barracks before but eventually she got accustomed to it. Ron, of course, had immediate playmates because everybody in the village was in the same state as we were, young, struggling students but most of whom had just been married a relatively short time. We had an opportunity during our first year at Shanks to visit with Marion's Aunt Pearl and Uncle Roy who lived in Scarsdale, across the Hudson from Nyack. Orangeburg, New York, the town closest to Shanks, was not very far from West Point. We were also close to some historic spots of the Revolutionary War, including the spot where Major Andre, the co-conspirator of Benedict Arnold in trying to sell out West Point, was executed.

In order to continue my G.I. Bill support payments I had to be enrolled in school, so I kept my enrollment for the summer session of 1949. However, since I still had to

earn some money, I made an arrangement with the professor just to do the reading rather than have to attend classes in a course on Russian literature. It worked out O.K. and I caddied at an exclusive golf club to earn some money as well as play golf on "caddie's day". Marion helped me do the required reading of such books as "Quiet Flows the Don" and "Anna Karenina", enough to get the credit for the course.

Marion's sister, Helen, came to stay with us in August 1949 while she attended the Julliard School of Music in New York City for six months. While she was in Shanks with us my brother, Martin, had an accident and Marion took Ron to California to help Betty for a week or so. I don't know how we stumbled on to it but Helen found something which would help me gain some weight. I only weighed about 135 lbs. at the time, but by the time Marion returned I had gained about ten pounds and was soon up to 150 lbs the most I had ever weighed in my life.

This was a good time to be in a prestigious university with top-notch professors. It was in 1948 that the state of Israel was set up, followed immediately by an invasion by the Arab nations with Israel successfully defeating them. There was also a rash of Soviet intelligence activities in the U.S. such as the Rosenbergs and Klaus Fuchs who gave away secrets on the atomic bomb. In 1949 the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) was negotiated to counteract the Warsaw Pact of the communist nations. Some of my professors were directly involved in advising on such things as the United Nations and NATO so the lectures and discussions were hot off the wire, so to speak, and UN Headquarters were right there in New York. Philip Moseley, my advisor, was one of the consultants in drafting the UN charter and was regularly being consulted by the U.S. government for input into matters affecting the UN.

In my second year at the School of International Affairs, I was selected to be one of the editors of The Journal of International Affairs. In addition to editorial duties, I had the auxilliary function of obtaining advertising for the Journal to help defray some of the cost of its production. Consequently, this provided me with an opportunity to deal with the advertising managers of some of the leading firms in New York involved in the publishing field, such as McGraw Hill, MacMillan etc. Our editorial policy was to keep advertising in the publication on an intellectually high plane. The Journal of International Affairs has become a highly respected journal in it's field and I am pleased to have been one of a group that got it going in the first place. One of my closest friends in the class was Bill Cates, who also served as an editor of the Journal of International Affairs. He later joined C.I.A. for awhile but resigned to be an investment banker. At one time he was an Assistant Secretary of the Treasury.

Since the course I was taking was considered a professional one rather than an academic one I was not required to submit a Master's thesis, per se. However, I did have to write several major papers in order to graduate. I wrote a hundred page document on the Truman Doctrine as well as a long paper on American agriculture and American Foreign Policy. I received my degree of Master of International Affairs in June 1950 from the then president of Columbia University, Dwight D. Eisenhower, later to become the President of the United States.

While still on campus I received a visit from a mysterious individual who never identified his organization but whom everybody knew to be from the Central Intelligence Agency, an organization chartered in 1947 to continue the work began during World War II by O.S.S. (Office of Strategic Services.) I had been interviewing with several firms including, amongst others, Chase Manhattan Bank in its international division. I really wasn't sure until we visited Washington D.C. after my graduation that my application was actually being processed for employment in C.I.A. and that all that was holding it up was getting a security clearance, a process which took quite a long time. Coincidentally, about the time for my graduation from Columbia, I was thinking about applying for the Air Force or Navy reserves to help my financial situation. Fortunately, I delayed getting in my application because in 1950, the war between North and South Korea was initiated by a North Korean invasion. The two countries had been divided into two governments in 1948. The Korean War, of course, required the entrance of the United States into another conflict which was to be a long, bloody one lasting until 1953. Dwight D. Eisenhower, the Nato Supreme Commander after he left the presidency of Columbia University, was elected president in 1952 and promised to end the Korean conflict. He served two terms with Richard M. Nixon as his vice-president.

We left Shanks Village after my graduation, although we didn't give up our apartment, waiting to do that after we returned from Utah. First of all we took a trip to Niagara Falls with Ron in tow, took the opportunity to visit Palmyra, N. Y. and the Martin Harris home then went down to Washington, D.C. to see Edith and Rex Johnson, Marion's sister and brother-in-law, who lived in Arlington, Virginia. We also wanted to check up to see about how long the clearance process would take before we took off for Utah. I was told that it might take three or four months so I had to go somewhere where I could get temporary employment to support the family until my C.I.A. clearance came through. Our trip to Utah was quite "forgettable". We traveled on limited funds and couldn't afford to stay in motels or anything like that. We did manage to do a little sightseeing on the way such as visiting Mark Twain's home and the Tom Sawyer fence in Hannibal, Missouri. Just about the time that

we crossed the Mississippi River at Burlington, Iowa, the car was making all kinds of funny noises. We stopped at some body shop that was open late on a Saturday night to find out if there was any repair facility open on a Sunday.

Fortunately they knew of one, so we stayed alongside the river in a park, got up early the next morning and clunked through Burlington until we found the repair place. The water pump had gone out so it needed to be replaced. We were lucky to find a part for a 1939 Buick in 1950 and it took practically all of my last G.I. bill check to pay for the repairs. We then suffered the rest of the trip with an overheating engine but managed finally to limp into Provo, Utah.

During the summer of 1950, Marion worked at the pipe plant outside of Provo and I got a job doing cleanup work around the new science building being constructed on the BYU campus. In addition, I worked out at the cannery in Spanish Fork. My companion was Les Raty, who also was waiting for a clearance from CIA. We had a good time together even though we were trying to work at two jobs (about 12 hours per day total). I started to get worried in September since I hadn't heard from the Agency at all so I interviewed for a job at Geneva steel in Industrial Relations. It didn't seem to matter that my degree was in International Relations. In fact, they were about ready to offer me a job so I called the personnel office at C.I.A. to tell them I needed to know one way or another.